DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Why Was the World Created?

Derech Hashem 1:2:1

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 1, Chapter 2, paragraph 1 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 4 January 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Why are we here?

Chapter 2 deals with the purpose of creation. The Rabbi called it a really important chapter: "If you haven't thought about this question in your life yet, then it's a problem." We should be asking regularly: why are we here, why do we exist, what are we living for?

He put the question to the group. "To serve God," said one. But does Hashem need us to serve Him? "To make Him happy," said another. But that would mean He needs us, and if He needs anything He is not perfect. Our offerings and our service are for our benefit, not His. So what is the purpose of creation as a whole?

Everything we do has a motive. What was Hashem's motive in creating us?

The answer in one line

The Ramhal answers in a single sentence, which the Rabbi said to remember for life: "The purpose of creation was for the Good One, blessed be His Name, to bestow His goodness upon others."

"That's it. That's the purpose of creation." The rest of this chapter and the next will explain how it works, but this is the header. If someone asks you why God created you: because God wants to do good, and He wants to bestow goodness upon me. As the verse in Tehillim says, the world was built on kindness.

This idea runs through all the Ramhal's books. If we could use the word "nature" for Hashem (and strictly we cannot), it is the nature of someone good to want to do good. A truly good person wants to give. Hashem, the ultimate goodness and perfection, wants to bestow goodness upon us.

A participant suggested that goodness is the primary purpose of existence. The Rabbi said it is not just the primary reason, it is the only reason. Another asked why, then, Hashem did not simply make man good, and what about all the pain and suffering in the world. The Rabbi asked him to park the question: this chapter and the next answer it.

Only Hashem is truly perfect

"Every chapter in the Ramhal, it's a brick on a brick." In Chapter 1 we learned that the only thing we can know about Hashem is that He is shalem, perfect. The Ramhal now builds on that: Hashem alone is the true perfection, free of every defect, and no other perfection is like His. Even the most perfect thing we could imagine besides Him is not true perfection; we only call it perfect relative to things that are less.

The Rabbi asked the group who they would call the most perfect human being. Suggestions included Einstein, Moshe Rabbenu and the Rambam. He said the Rambam may well be the most perfect person in his eyes, but as a human being he surely made mistakes. Even if we imagined someone who never did anything wrong, with impeccable wisdom and character, we would call him perfect only relative to everyone else. Complete and absolute perfection is found only in Hashem.

The problem: the best goodness is Hashem Himself

Now put two points together:

- A: Hashem is perfect.
- B: Hashem wants to bestow goodness.
- So, C: He wants to bestow perfect goodness, "the best wants to give the best," not just a little good.

But where is the perfect goodness found? Only in Hashem. So it seems the only way to give it would be to create other gods, which is impossible, since we learned that there can only be one.

The Rabbi addressed the old philosophical puzzle: can Hashem do anything? Can He make a rock He cannot lift, or make Himself ill? The answer is no, and that is not an imperfection. Hashem cannot make another god precisely because He is perfect and the only God. "It's an oxymoron."

The queen

He brought it down to an analogy he often uses. Imagine Queen Elizabeth as a perfect human being, with no jealousy, who wants all her citizens to have the best goodness. What is the best goodness? To be the queen. But she cannot make everyone queen: the definition of a queen is one person ruling the country.

What can she do? Imagine she had the supernatural ability to spend time with each of her 70 million citizens at once. Think how you would prepare and dress up for half an hour of tea alone with her, and how much pleasure you would have. (Substitute whoever you most admire.) She cannot make you the queen, but she can let you connect to her. And how much? It depends on you: "The more regal you are, the more etiquette you have, the more time you spend with me." She remains the only queen, yet gives her citizens the best goodness there is, by letting them be with her.

The solution: cleaving to Hashem

That is exactly what the Ramhal says. Hashem's wisdom decreed that this goodness would take the form of allowing created beings to cleave to Him, as much as they are able. No human being can be called perfect, since true perfection is with Hashem alone. But by attaching themselves to Him, they reach as much perfection as they can, through their connection to Him, and they enjoy His goodness to the extent they are able to.

"I'm still giving off my perfect goodness to you. But I'm still retaining it. You're just plugging into me." A participant compared it to a huge Zoom meeting with the queen, where how much each person gets depends on whether he has the video on or is doing something else. The Rabbi liked the point that it depends on how much we take, though he noted the analogy is imperfect, since here each person has the queen's undivided attention.

Another asked how health and wealth come into this. "We're jumping the gun... We're building bricks."

The conclusion of paragraph 1

So Hashem's intention in creation was to create someone who could benefit from His goodness, to the extent possible. That is the purpose of creation.

The Rabbi asked everyone to think about it until the next class: why is there bad in the world, why do we have to work for it, why not just plug every human being into Hashem directly? "Don't just accept what I'm telling you. Think about it further."

Summary

- The purpose of creation is that Hashem, who is good, wants to bestow goodness on others; this is the only reason for creation.
- Hashem does not need our service; it is for our benefit.
- Being perfect, He wants to give perfect goodness, which exists only in Himself, and He cannot create another god.
- So He created beings who can cleave to Him and enjoy His goodness as far as they are able, like a queen letting her subjects spend time with her.
- How much we connect depends on us, which the following paragraphs will explain.

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